

Jazz and the Other Arts

Though it has been almost impossible to grow up in the Western world since 1920 without hearing something influenced by jazz, until recently it has been rather difficult to hear much jazz in the strict sense of the word. After all, perhaps the most famous of all jazz records, Louis Armstrong's *West End Blues* which has been continuously in print since 1928, sold not much more than 20,000 copies in its first twenty years in Britain, which is modest, even by the standard of some pretty highbrow arts. Moreover, as we have seen, the jazz public has been, for historical and social reasons, rather sharply distinct from the rest of the public for the orthodox arts, even when it did not itself keep aloof from them. It is therefore not surprising that until recently jazz has had very little echo indeed among the rest of the creative arts.

The list of works influenced by, or inspired by, or 'about' jazz is therefore very unimpressive. It is obviously longest in music, though every compiler (and there have been several) is forced to fall back on the same names and works, mostly from the 1920s: Debussy's *Golliwog's Cakewalk*, Ravel's *L'Enfant et les sortilèges*, and piano concertos, Milhaud's *La Création du monde*, Stravinsky's *Histoire du soldat*, *Ragtime pour onze instruments*, and *Piano Rag Music*, all of which echo the post-1918 preoccupation of the French *avant-garde* with this type of exoticism, Krenek's *Jonny spielt auf* and Weill's music for Brecht, which reflects that of the German *avant-garde* with low life, Constant Lambert's *Rio Grande*, and the like.¹ Only in America, and there mainly on the verges of popular and light music, can we detect a more persistent jazz influence, notably in the musicals (Gershwin's *Porgy and Bess*, Marc Blitzstein's *The Cradle Will Rock*, Leonard Bernstein). Frankly, the record is modest. The history of modern classical music can still be written virtually without reference to jazz. Of the major contemporary

composers—say Schoenberg, Berg, Webern, Stravinsky, Bartók, Prokofiev, perhaps Shostakovich, Vaughan Williams, Sibelius, and Hindemith—only one has shown any signs of jazz influence; and as Hodeir rightly points out, his flirting with jazz was unimportant: ‘Stravinsky made history when he wrote *Le Sacre du printemps*; he placed himself on the margin of history when he wrote *Ragtime*.²

The list of literary works with a bearing on jazz is even less impressive, and, before the 1930s, quite negligible, if we except a few things by the irrepressible Cocteau. A few of the poets on the verges of (British) neo-romanticism and surrealism have written mediocre poems inspired by jazz players, and with titles like *An Elegy for Herschel Evans* (‘The band will continue its music, as life its laughter: the world will be gay or sad with age or season: and the marvellous sounds of jazz will thrill or bless ...’), or *A Measure for Cootie* (‘we play the way it comes to us, we play elegies for the past, blues for the present ... a trumpeter as you, a poet as I’), or *Piano—a Surrealist Prose Poem* (‘Piano shouting the licks of New York and the scabs of New Orleans the yellows and the browns and the blacks but above all the blues’).^{*} Auden experimented a little with the blues, in one case—the *Refugee Blues*—not at all unsuccessfully. There is by now a crop of generally mediocre novels about jazz and jazz players, and of late a certain amount of what may be called ‘jazz-steeped’ writing, e.g. by the San Francisco ‘beat generation’—Jack Kerouac *et al.*—who combine a passion for jazz with one for Zen Buddhism. The sociological interest of this stuff is real, the literary merit so far uncertain. The best piece of writing inspired by jazz is probably still one of the earliest—and one written, significantly enough, by a poet whose mode of life was highly unliterary even by American standards: Vachel Lindsay’s *The Daniel Jazz*.

Among black writers jazz has naturally been more influential, though even among them only a few, notably Langston Hughes, have been seriously and consistently influenced by the blues. Much of Hughes’s writing is plain blues, such as might be composed and sung by any guitar-picker:

Sun’s a settin’, this what I’m gonna sing.

*Sun's a settin', this is what I'm gonna sing:
I feels de blues a-comin', wonder what de blues'll bring.
Or the Gal's Cry for a Dying Lover:*

*Heard de owl a-hootin', knowed somebody's 'bout to die.
Heard the owl a-hootin', knowed somebody's 'bout to die.
Put ma head un'neath de kiver, started to moan an' cry.*

*Hound dawg's barkin', means he's gonna leave this world.
Hound dawg's barkin', means he's gonna leave this world.
O, Lawd have mercy on a po' black girl.*

*Black an' ugly, but he sho' do treat me kind.
I'm black an' ugly, but he sho' do treat me kind.
High-in-heaben Jesus, please don't take this man o' mine.*³

Hughes is pretty consistently aware of jazz and the blues as components of black American life; but even among writers of his people this awareness was not always habitual.

This paucity and poverty of jazz literature is all the more extraordinary since, as we have seen, the world of jazz is, at the very least, fantastically good “copy” for any writer with an interest in human beings. Moreover, jazz itself has produced at least two types of literature of value: the poetry of the blues, and the talked autobiography; not to mention the literary experimentalism of ‘jive talk’. It is little short of incomprehensible that an environment which has turned out stuff like the following passage almost by routine should not have tempted the poets and prose writers more:

But when you write about me, please don't say I'm a jazz musician. Don't say I'm a musician or a guitar player—just write Big Bill was a well-known blues singer and player and has recorded 260 blues songs from 1925 up till 1952; he was a happy man when he was drunk and playing with women; he was liked by all the blues singers, some would get a little jealous sometimes but Bill would buy a bottle of whisky and

they all would start laughing and playing again, Big Bill would get drunk and slip off from the party and go home to sleep....⁴

The balance-sheet in painting and sculpture is even more meagre, unless we include the flourishing but recent trade of decorating the sleeves of long-playing records. Fortunately for the arts (and not only for those concerned with jazz), popular records rely largely on the eye-catching appeal of their covers, and these are therefore much more interesting and enterprising than the miserable designs on so many classical LPs.

Fortunately for jazz, a large body of commercial artists have always been among its most loyal and passionate supporters. The sleeves of jazz LPs therefore maintain a pretty high standard. Admittedly most of them get their effects by montage (mostly of photos), layout, and type design.

Comparatively few are painted or drawn. Admittedly also jazz illustration of this kind has produced its crop of clichés, the shirt-sleeved black piano player at his upright being the most common. But the ‘applied art’ of jazz is a flourishing affair none the less. It is the ‘pure art’ which has always languished. Jazz has tempted one or two abstractionists (several artists have attempted to re-create its sensations in abstract films), but hardly any representationalists. Perhaps this is because the iconography of jazz is a triumph for photography: how much else, one may ask, need be said when the camera already says so much about these concentrated, grave faces and shut eyes behind the instrumental mouthpieces?

For almost the only art which has taken jazz seriously and on its own terms is that of photography. The crop of jazz films, or of films with some relation to jazz, is small enough; for over most of its history the subject did not appeal to the indeterminate mass public by which the film industry lives. Nevertheless it is not negligible. There is *Jammin’ the Blues* by Granz and Gjon Mili; or *Momma Don’t Allow* by Karel Reisz, one of the few films which also deals with the jazz public. There is *Jazz on a Summer’s Day*, a documentary about a Newport Jazz Festival, and bits and pieces smuggled into commercial films, doubtless by devoted jazz-lovers connected with their making. The actual commercial films on jazz subjects, mostly of the usual Hollywood ‘famous show-biz lives’ type, multiplied towards the end of the fifties, but remained totally vacuous. But above all, since the early fifties in Hollywood, since the late fifties in American television and the European cinema, there has been the fashion for giving films, often about crime, sex, and lost generations, serious and uncompromising jazz scores,

mostly very modernist ones. Musically the French have been most successful in arranging such liaisons, notably with sound-tracks by Miles Davis and the Modern Jazz Quartet. The most ambitious American attempt, an Ellington score for a mammoth murder story, will not be counted among the master's most successful works. However, for obvious reasons, the combination of jazz with the James Dean, Marlon Brando, TV-Private-Eye kind of film in the U.S.A. is much more of a marriage, much less of a passing affair, than in most European films, for jazz in America is a common language and not merely, as in France, a form of upper class slang.

Perhaps the closest combination of jazz with other media has occurred in television commercials and cartoon films. Probably this is the only genre of modern art which is as fully impregnated by the influence of jazz as is ordinary life in our times. Nevertheless, compared to previous epochs, the later fifties marked a very striking *rapprochement* between jazz and the only other original mass arts of the twentieth century, those of the moving camera.

There remains the ballet, an art which one would expect to be sensitive to jazz, which is, after all, essentially music combined with movement. However, the classical ballet (even as loosened up by Diaghilev and others) rests on a stylized vocabulary of movement which is extraordinarily difficult to combine with the very different vocabulary of black American dancing. Even *Petrushka*, danced by Harlem dancers, would look as odd as Mozart's clarinet quintet would sound if played by Sidney Bechet with his normal intonation; a Harlem *Petrushka* would be quite a good experiment nevertheless. Semi-heterodox ballet companies, such as the French Champs Elysées have allowed themselves to be influenced by jazz, with indifferent success, but in the main jazz has affected ballet most—and most fruitfully—where it is least of an orthodox art: in the dancing in American cabarets, vaudeilles, musical shows, and films. (We need not specially mention the occasional companies which specialize in exoticism or black folk-lore, such as Katherine Dunham's Company.) Jazz has patently transformed what we may call the democratic as against the aristocratic or classical ballet. More precisely, like modern ballroom dancing, modern American musical-show dancing is inconceivable without jazz influence.

Taking it all in all, the influence of jazz has been surprisingly small. If we consider only the 'outsiders', those creative artists who have not grown up within the world of jazz, whether as players or fans, or in some other

close connexion with it, it becomes negligible. Other kinds of exotic music have produced far more. The cultural field is littered with literary and musical works inspired, however remotely, by the Spanish equivalent of the jazz scene, from Gautier and Mérimée onwards. Its visual props—the shawls, combs, castanets, and *vaquero* costume which are the Andalusian equivalents to the zoot suit, the characteristic gestures and movements of flamenco dancing—are familiar to every civil service clerk with cultural ambitions, from Cardiff to Vladivostok, through pictures, ballets, operas, and the rest. Not so jazz which, with all its remarkable power to expand and proselytize, has rarely succeeded in capturing its public unless, like the Jesuits, it caught its subjects young. I know men and women of high intelligence, great musical sensitiveness and expertise, and almost painful eagerness to discover what others see in jazz, who are quite unable to see the difference in quality between two jazz pieces, while their contemporaries, who heard their first Fletcher Hendersons and Armstrongs at the age of fifteen, have no difficulty in doing so. Possibly a prior training in the orthodox arts is an active disqualification; for though innumerable people have widened an original love of jazz to include classical music, the opposite evolution has been much rarer.

The non-musical achievements of jazz among the arts are therefore largely in the hands of the ‘insiders’—the musicians and singers, and the public which has grown up with jazz. Since a great many people have grown up with it, its cultural infertility is still rather surprising, especially in literature. After all, though the films have so far produced no literary masterpieces, they have provoked a remarkable crop of technical and analytical writing, a significant body of poetry—at least about Charlie Chaplin—ranging from Hart Crane and Umberto Saba through Rafael Alberti to Aragon and Mayakovsky, and a large block of semi-sociological, semi-satirical fiction mainly, it must be admitted, expressing the self-laceration of script-writers. However, the world of jazz is not comparable to that of the films. Like the world of the stage, the circus, the classical musician, it is far more self-contained, not to say esoteric: a craftsmen’s and critics’ world. It is self-contained also, inasmuch as for most of its earlier history players and public got their cultural satisfactions almost exclusively within it, and had much of their remaining energies pre-empted by the desire to crusade for its recognition. Between the pure ‘jazz fan’ whose chief object (whatever his profession) was to advertise the cause, and the

ordinary adolescent, for whom jazz was simply a part of the environment as beach umbrellas are in seaside resorts, there was, and is, a large void. Normally those who make the works of art out of other arts, or out of special professional worlds, are situated in this intermediate space; in the world of jazz it has been almost empty.

On the other hand, this world has had the unique gift of producing articulate artists. Much of the effort of the 'jazz intellectuals' has been devoted to making them articulate, rather than to making themselves articulate about jazz, but this does not alter the fact. The jazz musician does not of course normally paint, or sculpt, or make films, but he does—he can hardly avoid doing so—use words. His prose is embodied in a vast corpus of 'spoken literature', mainly autobiographical, out of which Hentoff and Shapiro have produced a magnificent montage, the book *Hear Me Talkin' to Ya* (the title is borrowed from a record by Louis Armstrong). This sort of prose is not easily quotable in extracts, for it makes its effects, if so purposeful a term has any meaning here, by accumulation. Only now and again, notably in the talk of the blues singers, does it achieve a rhythmic ironic vividness of dialogue for which good dramatists would give much: LEROY: 'Yeah. So we had a few Negroes down there that wasn't afraid of white peoples or talk back to them. They called those people crazy....' NATCHEZ: '... crazy people ... (LEROY: 'Yeah.') '... I wonder why they called them crazy because they speak up for his rights....' LEROY: 'Yeah, they call them crazy.' NATCHEZ: 'I had an uncle like that and they hung him.... They hung him down there because they say he was crazy and he might ruin the other Negroes.' (LEROY: 'That's right.') 'See, and that is why they hung him, see, because he was a man, that he worked he wanted pay; and he could figure as good as the white man, and he had as good an education as some of the white—better than some of the white people down there.' (LEROY: 'Yeah.') '... 'cause a lot of them down there would come to him for advice'.⁵

If the prose is just the prose of life—though this is not often found in literature—the poetry is unique, especially when it has what someone called the unique talent of the blacks for making poetry out of words of one syllable. The blues are unquestionably the finest body of living folk-poetry in the modern industrial world. They consist primarily of a large body of five-stressed rhyming couplets with the first line repeated, which are combined, modified, and augmented to taste. Like other folk-poetry, they

are concerned almost exclusively with straightforward statements, questions, or appeals, and not at all with literary ornamentation. Even their similes are used for precision and not for evocation:

Got the world in a jug, got the stopper in my hand

or

*Love is just like a faucet, it turns off and on, Love is like a faucet, it
turns off and on,
Sometimes when you think it's on, baby, it has turned off and gone.*

Their symbols and poetic props are either straightforward, or standard formulae such as any minstrel uses as fill-ins: the sun which rises and goes down, the railroad, the house, the wind, the graveyard:

*Sun rises in the east, and I declare it sets in the west.
Sun rises in the east, and I declare it sets in the west.
Ain't it hard to tell, hard to tell, which woman will treat you the best.*

*There's three trains ready, but none ain't going my way, I said there's
three trains ready, and none ain't going my way.
But the sun's gonna shine in my back door some day.*

*Blow, wind, blow, blow my baby back to me
Blow, wind, blow, blow my baby back to me
Since she's gone, nothing's like it used to be.*

The blues are therefore not poetic because the singer wants to express himself or herself in a poetic manner. He or she wants to say what has to be said as best it can, as in the famous *Make Me a Pallet on the Floor*—the song of a poor New Orleans prostitute—where the only ‘technical effect’ is that of the repetition of lines and phrases, which, as it happens, makes the content of the song astonishingly poignant; an ‘effect’ which arises naturally out of the repetitive pattern of ordinary popular speech:

Make me a pallet on your floor,

*Make me a pallet on your floor,
Make me a pallet, baby, a pallet on your floor,
So when your good girl comes, she will never know.*

*Make it very soft and low,
Make it, babe, very soft and low,
Make it, baby, near your kitchen door,
So when your good girl comes, she will never know.*

*I'll get up in the morning and cook you a red hot meal, I'll get up in
the morning and cook you a red hot meal, To show you, baby, I
'preciate what you done for me When you made me a pallet on
your floor.*

*Make it soft and low,
Make it, baby, soft and low,
If you feel like layin' down, babe, with me on the floor, When your
good girl comes home, she will never know.*

It is remarkable how complex and sophisticated an effect can be achieved simply by the slight variation of repeated lines, in words, rhythm, and context.[‡]

The casual way in which the blues gets its poetic effects, rather as pebbles are shaped by water, may be illustrated by a specific example, the *Red River Blues*, which Mr Sonny Terry, the singer and harmonica player, tells me is the first blues he ever learned:

*Which way, which way, do that blood red river run?
Which way, which way, do that blood red river run?
Run from my back door to the rising sun.*

*I hate to see that rising sun go down
I hate to see that rising sun go down
It make me feel I'm on my last go roun'.*

*Which way, which way, do that blood red river run?
Which way, which way, do that blood red river run?
Run from my window to the rising sun.*

This is a special development of a widely known genre, the ‘river’ blues, which normally deals either with the effects of floods on the life of riverside dwellers, or—a familiar poetic conceit—the river which divides a man from his love. (I am informed by an expert, Mr Alexis Korner, that the singer Josh White recognized a song sung by Big Bill Broonzy as the *Red River Blues*, though it runs “Mississippi River is so long, deep, and wide, Can’ see my good girl standin’ on the other side’, and so on in that vein.) The middle stanza of the present version is a familiar blues verse, best known as the opening of the *St Louis Blues*, from which it may very well have been lifted. It is a fair guess that the ‘red river’ came into the song originally via the well-known cowboy song *Red River Valley*, which is of course about geography, not colour. At some stage the Red River (which runs from Texas, along the Oklahoma border, through Arkansas and Louisiana into the Mississippi) turned into a coloured river, the colour of blood. How did it link up with the sun? Perhaps because someone remembered the red glow of a river against the sunset? The blood-red river, seen from a house, becomes a symbol of life, the rising and setting sun of its impermanence. A collection of poetic bricks, chipped to size, turns, we do not quite know how, into a reflexion on life and the inevitability of death. Other verses drop off, until what is left is a concentrated lyric song.[±]

The blues is full of such poetic bricks, to be put together by the singer as he chooses: verses, and particularly standard lines which the minstrel can insert whenever he or she can’t think of anything else, or wants to return to familiar ground:

You see me laughing, just to keep from cryin’

or:

Take me back, baby, try me one more time

(no listener will forget the intensity which Bessie Smith puts into this line)

or:

I looked down the road, as far as I could see

(a very characteristic line for the travelling singer) or the typically implacable

You must reap what you sow:

*I told you darling, long time ago
You goin' to reap for what you sow*

*And what you sow, gonna make you reap
And what you reap, gonna make you weep
Someday, sweetheart.*[§]

But behind the elementary, though remarkably effective, poetic apparatus of the blues there lies a view of life, which that apparatus is designed to express with the utmost directness and economy of means. It is this which gives the blues their remarkable power, even when they are little more than doggerel:

*I'm going away, babe, just to wear you off my mind I'm going away,
babe, just to wear you off my mind.
If I stay around here, I'll be troubled all the time.*

*So help me, honey, but I don't love you:
So help me, honey, but I don't love you.
Well, I just don't like them funny old ways you do.*

*It's raining here, babe, storming on the sea:
Raining here, storming on the sea:
You mistreat a good man when you mistreat me.*

*I'm sorry, baby, sorry to my heart
Sorry, baby, sorry to my heart
We've been together so long, now we've got to part (Joe Turner,
Going Away Blues.)*

This view of life is adult, truthful, totally without illusions, and humbug, which is why so much of such poetry sounds remarkably like the verse of

Brecht, who in turn drew his inspiration from the directness of popular songs:

*Oh, life is like that,
Well, that's what you got to do,
Well, and if you don't understand,
Peoples I'm sorry for you.*

*Sometimes you'll be held up, sometimes held down,
Sometimes your best friends don't even want you round, you know.*

*Well, life is like that,
Well, that's what you got to do ...
(From the LP *Blues in the Mississippi Night*, Pye-Nixa.)*

Truth is what is in the blues; truth is what the blues singers cherish above all, and the word which recurs time and again in their conversation when they grope for an explanation of what they are after, and attempt to separate their own songs from those which are merely made to earn money.⁹¹

This is no doubt why British adolescents listen to the voice of blues singers as they would not to those of parents, teachers, or other poets, taking in 'the truth' in hushed silence in cellar clubs or bedrooms. Nobody beats around the bush in the blues; neither about life, death, drink, money, or even love.

Few things are more ironic, and characteristic, than that the name of this diamond-hard, lucid, and uncompromising idiom has come to be used by Tin Pan Alley to describe the mood of self-pity and superficial maundering which it believes to be characteristic of those who do not immediately succeed in sleeping with their girls (*I'm feeling blue over you*, etc.). For self-pity and sentimentality are not in the blues. On the contrary. Its fundamental assumption is that men and women must live as it comes, or if they cannot stand that they must die. They laugh and cry because they are human, but they know it cannot help them. Nothing can, unless they help themselves; for heaven is rarely in the blues, which is a purely secular song, and there is no God, though sometimes, as in Bessie Smith's *Blue Spirit Blues*, there is hell. In this world 'a good man is hard to find', and when he is found, he won't bring unmixed advantage:

*Now it's ashes to ashes, sweet papa, dust to dust, I said ashes to
ashes, I mean dust to dust:
Now show me the man any woman can trust.*

Like the world of the disorganized and beaten-down labourers among whom this wonderful idiom grew up, the world of the blues is tragic, and helpless: as Bessie Smith—as usual the definitive voice of the blues—once put it:

You cain' trust nobody, you might as well be alone.

And you remain alone. For when the men and women who sing the blues turn to sing of collective salvation, whether secular through the union, or religious through the churches, they rarely sing in the idiom of the blues, but in the idiom of the hymn or gospel song, which is its spiritual brother. Its poetic achievement is equally real, but except for a few revivalist hymns such as the sadly familiar *When the Saints Go Marching In*, it does not belong so intimately to jazz as the secular blues. Perhaps because there are few saints in jazz.

Like all folk-poetry, the blues is intended to be sung; and nobody who has heard Bessie Smith sing the *Reckless Blues* or Ma Rainey sing *See See Rider*, or the young Chippie Hill *Trouble in Mind*, can read the words as other but a faint shadow of the real poetry of the blues; for it is the timbre of the voice, the passion, and the marvellous flexibility and rhythmic suspension of the vocal line which turn lines like 'When I wasn't nothing but a child' or 'Now that I am growing old' into statements as definitive of their kind as:

*Et la mort à mes yeux dérobant la clarté
Rend au jour qu'ils souillaient toute sa pureté.*

But even as a verbal skeleton, the blues are a literary achievement of considerable importance, and so far the most important non-musical by-product (or rather non-musical aspect) of jazz.⁶

Notes

1. Rex Harris, *Jazz* (Penguin Books).
2. Hodeir, 263.
3. From *Fine Clothes to the Jew* (New York 1927). I have written the stanzas out in the usual three-line form.
4. W. Broonzy and Y. Bruynoghe, *Big Bill Blues* (London 1955).
5. Alan Lomax, *Blues in the Mississippi Night* (Pye-Nixa NJL 8).
6. The best collections of blues verses so far available are the files of the New York *Jazz Review*, which prints a selection in each issue, Paul Oliver's *Blues Fell This Morning*, and Iain Lang's pioneer *Background to the Blues*.

* In fairness to the poets concerned I shall not embarrass them by quoting their names at this late date.

‡ Since the final consonants are very slurred in Southern U.S. speech, the rhymes are true rhymes—e.g. 'flo'—'do'—'know'. I have, so far as possible, spelled out the words in standard form, in order to avoid the impression of 'coon English', which black Americans dislike.

‡ The tune is approximately that of the beautiful *Trouble in Mind*. It has been recorded, Alexis Korner informs me, by Brownie McGhee, Sonny Terry, and Leadbelly. A more conventional version by Josh White is available in Britain (*The Josh White Story*, vol. II).

* Brownie McGhee. I need hardly say that I am greatly indebted to Messrs Brownie McGhee, Sonny Terry, Big Bill Broonzy, and James Rushing, all of them fine blues singers, with whom I have been privileged to discuss the blues on their British visits.

¶ Thus Saint Louis Jimmy, a veteran singer, attempting to explain why Europeans like the blues: 'In Europe they like stories, they like the truth; that's why they like the blues, not all this foolishness ... because the blues is the truth about how they mistreat people, that's what the blues is.' Similar statements are in print or on record by Big Bill Broonzy, Lightning Hopkins, and doubtless others.